STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 01 · A Quiet Tuesday

Transcript · Wes Hart

Alright. Hey. I'm glad you came. Uh, go ahead and look around for a second. Some of you have been in rooms like this for years. Same folding chairs. Same kind of quiet right before somebody starts talking. You could, you could probably run this thing yourself, right? Glad you're back. Some of you, this is your first time through that door. You grabbed a chair near the back, and you're still deciding if that was a mistake. It wasn't. And a couple of you got dragged here. A buddy said, come with me, and you said, honestly, I don't know what you said. But you came. That counts. A few of you came straight from work. Boots still on. And, I mean, if you'd gone home first, you weren't coming back out. So. You're here. Here's what I want you to hear up front. Every man in this room belongs in the chair he's in. If you're young, and you're still waiting for somebody to tell you you're a man, you're on time. If you're married with little kids climbing all over you, you're on time. Divorced, still a dad, the house got real quiet, or you figured, you know, this was for a younger guy, you're on time. Nobody in here is a guest. I mean that. My name's Wes. Wes Hart. I'm a husband, I'm a dad, I work for a living, and I've sat in, uh, a lot of rooms like this one. Usually in the back. This is Steadfast Men. You'll figure out the name.

So this is night one. Here's how the next few months go, and then I'll quit talking about the plan and get to it. We meet like this, one session at a time. Twenty-four of them. Every night's got the same bones. I'll teach for a while. You'll have your Bible open, and a workbook in front of you. Then we go to the tables, and you do the part I can't do for you. And you leave with one move for the week. One. Not a list. Next time you walk in, somebody at your table's gonna ask how it went. That's the whole system. Show up, tell the truth, do the move. Tonight we start with an ordinary day. Next week we look at why that's been so hard. After that, the four marks. Okay. Phone face down. Let's go.

Before we get into it, let me see a show of hands. How many of you told somebody you were just coming to, uh, check it out? Go on. Nobody's writing it down. Yeah. That's about what I figured. A whole room full of guys just checking it out. With a name tag on. That's alright. I checked it out too, once. I'm still here. Look, a man who can laugh in a room like this can usually tell the truth in one. And we're gonna need both. So here's the thing I wish somebody had told me, plain, a long time ago. A man's life gets decided on the days nobody photographs.

Luke sixteen, verse ten. New International Version. Whoever can be trusted with very little can also be trusted with much, and whoever is dishonest with very little will also be dishonest with much. Very little. A man is trusted on an ordinary day. Okay. I call that day a Tuesday. If you vanish on a Thursday, call it Thursday. The name isn't magic. The day is. Nothing on it worth a suit. You come home tired, or you never left the apartment, and the loudest thing in the building

might be, uh, your phone. There's a sentence you could say. Or swallow. A yes you could keep after the feeling has gone home. That's where a man gets made. Or where he settles, without ever standing up to announce it. I have asked God to make me a better man, and then spent half an hour on my phone comparing leaf blowers. Very spiritual about the mulch. The prayer was real. The leaf blower was a way to feel busy while I stayed the same man. I have a gift for that. I mean, a lot of us do. We will research a tool like it owes us money. We will not look at our own ordinary day unless somebody saves us a chair. You let somebody save you a chair. Stay in it. Let me tell you a Tuesday of mine, so you know I'm not up here on a balcony. My daughter had a bike. The back tire had been soft for two days. Maybe four. She asked me on an ordinary afternoon, right when I got home. Not a crisis. A tire. She said, can we fix it, together. I said, after supper. And I meant it. At that hour, I was a good father.

So supper happened. Then I sat down with my laptop, because there was one thing from the day I didn't want waiting on me in the morning. One thing. I told myself— I told myself it was one thing. It turned into the next thing. I could hear her in the other room. At some point she wheeled that bike to the edge of the patio and went back to her schoolwork. I didn't see her do it. I found the bike, last trip of the night, when I let the dog out. The house was quiet. The patio light was on. The tire was still soft. The pump was still in the hall closet, right where I had pictured the two of us using it. Then I fixed it. In the dark. By myself. And I felt useful. Which is, uh, a dangerous feeling for a man who just missed the point. In the morning she saw the tire and said, oh, thanks. That was the whole sentence. She had already stopped waiting. I did the job and missed the girl. I was somewhere else, and she learned it before I did. Listen. I am not down on work. I mean, the tire did need air. The lie under the day is sneakier than laziness. The lie says, I was busy, so I must have been there. I wasn't there. How many of you have had a big day you were sure would change you? A vow you meant. A hallway outside a hospital room. A morning you walked out of a church different. Or you thought you did. Hands, if you've had one. Keep them up if the ordinary day after it looked a lot like the ordinary day before it. Yeah. Put them down. Mine too. The big day was real. God likes a marked day. He builds them on purpose. What a marked day cannot do is give you a habit. A habit is what repeated work leaves on a man. On the days people are watching, most of us know our lines, right? We clean up. We say the sentence. Tuesday is the day the room is empty. That's why it counts.

Now. A Tuesday doesn't clap. A Tuesday doesn't post the picture. A Tuesday tells the truth to the people who had to live next to you. And if you live alone, it tells the truth to God, who was in the apartment the whole time. Look at your hands. Yesterday those hands were busy. I'm not against busy. Find, uh, one thing they did that a person in your life could not have hired out. Not a task. A presence. If the house is just you, then somebody you are still responsible to love. If nothing honest comes, don't dress it up. Open your workbook. In the margin, write one word. Gone. Phone. Work. Later. Easy. Whatever the true word is. Don't show your neighbor. We're coming back to it. Waiting wears a costume, and the costume is competence. If you hear stop

waiting and you picture a guy who never sits down, you came to the wrong talk. I mean, rest is good. A nap is allowed. A quiet evening is a gift. Waiting is a different animal. Waiting, the kind I mean, is being absent from what's yours while you are busy with something else. A while back I owed my wife a speech. Just a sentence. A true thing I'd been carrying, about a way I'd been short with her and then acted like it had expired on its own. I practiced it at a red light. I had the true sentence. The one that would have cost me. And a softer one behind it, you know, in case I lost my nerve. By the driveway, the true one was gone. I walked in and said, long day. She got a weather report. I got to feel like I'd shown up. We were a few feet apart. I was finishing a conversation she was never in.

Can I tell you what he asked me. Years ago an older man, in a group I belonged to, asked me something I still don't enjoy. He'd earned the right. He said, what did you do yesterday that the people in your house could not have hired out? I was ready. I'd worked a full day. I'd fixed a dripping faucet that had been talking to us for a month. Maybe two. I'd cleared a pile of messages like a hero. I gave him the list the way a boy turns in homework. He nodded. Patient. Almost kind. Then he said, I didn't ask what you finished. I asked where you were. That question clears the furniture out of a man. You can be the hero of your task list and a stranger at your own table. You can, you know, live by yourself and grade yourself kindly, because the walls don't argue. The faucet got fixed. I was still not there. I spent a stretch of my twenties waiting on a feeling. I thought manhood would arrive like a package I hadn't ordered. Some morning the hesitation would be gone and real life would start. The package never— the package never came. The hesitation just got older with me. Ordinary days came instead, and I spent a lot of them waiting for a mood those days were never going to bring. Well. If you're young, and you're waiting on the real season to start, hear it from a brother who wasted a few. This is the season. The day you already have is the job. If you're single, a wife is not the starting gun. Marriage is a good gift. It is not the day you become a man. If the house is loud and short on sleep, cereal on the counter, you are in the middle of it. If the house broke, go slow, and stay. A wound is real. It is not permission to disappear. If the work is going well, a longer day than anybody required is still different from being present. And if you think the verb retired when the job did, it didn't. I need you in this room.

First Corinthians thirteen, verse eleven. When I was a child, I talked like a child, I thought like a child, I reasoned like a child. When I became a man, I put the ways of childhood behind me. Paul does not say, when I was a child I had toys. He names the way he talked, the way he thought, the way he reasoned. All three live on the inside. You can carry a mortgage, a title, and a reputation people trust, and still be reasoning like a boy who only moves when the mood is already up. A child's yes isn't fake. That's what, uh, makes it tricky. It's real, and it lasts exactly as long as the feeling that made it. Then it wanders off, and the child is surprised anybody expected it to stay. A man has put that way behind him. His yes is still standing later, when the mood has left the building. Here's the sentence I want to hand you. I've held it up against my

own ordinary days for a long time. I have not found the place where it lies. Here it is. Slow. Let it land. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Write that line at the table, in your own hand. Don't swap a word to make it sound more like you. It doesn't need the help. Four marks. Not one of them is a mood you wait on. Today we stay on the first. Stop waiting. The other three get their own sessions. If you try to swallow all four before you stand up, you leave with a speech and no practice. Stop waiting. Stop being gone from what is yours.

Look. The verb. I put the ways of childhood behind me. They did not fall off in his sleep. A birthday didn't knock them loose. A man put them behind him on purpose. Nothing in those four marks happens while you watch your own life from the cheap seats. Age doesn't do the putting. I've known men barely out of their teens who have started. I have been well past young and still waiting to feel like starting. How do I say this. The feeling is a poor foreman. It will not show up and run the job. Some of you were never shown this. Nobody stood next to you on a plain day and said, here, this is what a man does when nobody is clapping. I'm not scolding you for that. A lot of us are still, you know, half-waiting on a father to finish a sentence he never started. Paul did not say, when my father finally did his job. He said, when I became a man, I put the ways behind me. The invitation is still open. It does not ask your age, or for a ring, or for a title. Go back to what Jesus said. Very little. That is a Tuesday phrase. We want the test we could brag about. Jesus is talking about a manager and a little bit of money, and the principle walks out of the ledger and sits down in a kitchen. God trusts a man from small to large. A tone of voice when you're tired. A message you owe and keep sliding to tomorrow. Whether you sit with the people who share your life, or pass through them on the way to being useful. See the word you wrote. That word is very little. It will not impress a stranger. It is what Jesus says will tell on you when the stakes grow up. If I play games with my attention on an ordinary day, I will play games when the room is full. I've watched it. I mean, in me first.

Matthew seven, verse twenty-four. Therefore everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock. A house does not stand on a mood. Puts them into practice. Not, hears them and gets stirred up. Practice is an ordinary-day word. The picture right after is a storm. Rain on the roof. Water coming up the yard. Wind beating the walls. The house stayed up. The storm did not ask whether the big day had meant anything. The house held because of days nobody drove past to admire. I have come home from a couple of days with other men, sure the inside of me had been, uh, rearranged. I reorganized a drawer. I found a label maker. I labeled things that were doing fine without a label. My wife did not receive that as revival. She received it as a man with leftover adrenaline and a new hobby. The feeling was honest. The drawer was straighter. The ordinary day after was the same man, unless I practiced once the adrenaline left. A burst feels like a new life. Practice is the life.

A man I've known for years. I'll call him, uh, Glenn. Good man. Showed up to his boy's games and stood on the sideline with his phone in his hand, in case something blew up. Nothing blew up. Something always might have. His boy played. Glenn could tell you the score, which fooled both of them for a while. After one game the boy said, did you see the steal. Glenn said, yeah, good job. He said it like a man filling in a blank. The boy stopped asking. No explosion. A boy who learned to stop looking over. We talked later, by the bleachers, once the gym had emptied. Glenn said, I'm at every game. I said, your phone is— your phone is at every game. You're in the notifications, hoping something needs you more than he does. He didn't fight me. A man who fights that sentence is usually buying another month of the same absence. He started leaving the phone in the car. Three games. He hated the first one. His hands didn't know where to live. By the third, he was watching. The boy never thanked him. He looked over after a play, and Glenn was looking back. Glenn told me he got choked up over nothing. It wasn't nothing. Somebody had started expecting him again. That's the risk of coming back. People might need you. Waiting keeps the expectations small and calls that peace, fair?

One more man. Howard is late in his sixties. Retired. And he had earned a rest. He told me he'd done his years and figured he'd earned the right to be done. Afternoons were a sandwich and a television that did the arguing for him. His grandson asked him to come see a project at school. Howard said he was tired. He was. He was also becoming a man who only showed up where nothing would be asked. He went. He sat in a plastic chair and survived it. On the ride home the boy talked the whole way. A map. A teacher. Nothing that will ever be on a résumé. Howard called me that night. He said, I thought the job was over. The boy didn't get the memo. So if the job is over, the work of being a man did not clock out with it. Somebody in reach still needs you in the room. You are not extra in here. You are evidence the verb still has a pulse. I want to slow down. Some of you are tired in a way a talk can bruise if the man up front is careless. You've been carrying weight. Work that takes what it takes. A house full of need. A quiet you didn't order. Maybe a failure that still pulls up a chair beside you. Rest is a gift. Sleep, some nights, is the faithful thing. One quiet evening is not a closed life. What's the word. Vanishing. It's when you leave and call the leaving peace. I have done it on days when I was not at the end of my rope. I was just comfortable being gone. I told myself the people around me were fine. Some of them got good at being fine without me. If you're barely holding on, hear an invitation, not a whip. If you're comfortable, don't borrow the other man's excuse. God is not confused about which one you were. You probably aren't either.

Stay with me. Here's the turn. You are not stuck as the boy who only moves when the mood is up. You can put that way behind you on a day that will never applaud. One small yes. Small enough to do after the feeling has gone home. The God who sees a plain Tuesday can give a man, um, strength to walk back into his own life. If you trust Christ, you are not manufacturing manhood to win this room. A Father has already claimed you. You put a childish way down because you belong to Him. If you aren't sure about Him yet, the chair is still yours. Start with

an honest day. He has never been afraid of an honest man. Here's what I hope you carry out. Not a new personality. One hour of an ordinary day you can actually see. One small yes that will still be standing when the feeling leaves. And this. You are on time. The last ordinary day is the one you answer for. The next one is the one you practice. Not a future version of you. You. Don't fix a bike in the dark and tell yourself you were present. Don't sand a true sentence down until all that's left is long day. Don't stand on a sideline inside your phone and call it love. Where were you. A man's life gets decided on the days nobody photographs. The days with an audience mostly reveal what the plain ones already built. A steadfast man stops waiting right there. His yes outlasts the mood.

The tables are ready. Open your workbook and work that part together. Don't explain the chapter to each other. Don't rescue a man from the question with advice. Here is what I want you wrestling. Where in your ordinary days do you keep an aisle instead of a seat? You were in the building. Were you in the room? What cover is closest right now? Living on options. Hiding inside a good job. Or treating some later season as the real start. Name your cover. Leave your neighbor's alone. Who in reach already knows if you showed up last Tuesday? If you can't think of a name, that answer is an answer. And say this out loud. One sentence. Where did you disappear last Tuesday without calling it that? Then write the move. Not a speech. My next move on a Tuesday is. One meal with the phone in another room. Not in your pocket, where it can, uh, buzz you out of your own life. Another room. If you live alone, you still sit down. The phone still leaves. And one small yes that will still be there if the feeling leaves. Put the day on the page. A move you can fail at is the only kind that can make a man. Text one man. Ask him what he did with his Tuesday. Let him ask you the same. Send it before you walk out, if you can. An ordinary day nobody else knows about is a day you will explain away. The line for your handwriting is this. Tuesday is where a man is made, or he settles. Write it once. I'll say the four one more time, and then I'm done talking. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. You came to check it out. You sat down. That was the first yes. Don't waste it. Get out of that chair, and go sit with men.